

Founding members — pitch cards

Memorise one spine. Swap one line. Everything else is conversation.

The spine — four beats, twenty seconds

1 • OPEN	“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. A member has to vouch for you to get in — and if you behave badly, they go too.”
2 • SWAP	The angle line for their type — the only beat that changes.
3 • PICTURE	“Think about your group chat. Someone’s got a spare room going and you trust it straight away, because you know who you’re dealing with.”
4 • CLOSE	“Would you actually use this?” · “Who are the three Manhattanites you’d vouch for?”

The four motives — if you memorise only one thing

MOTIVE	THE PERSON	TYPES	THE MOVE
PAIN	Has suffered the alternative	Movers, Newcomers	<i>Tell their story back to them.</i>
PRIDE	Their judgement about people carries weight	Locals, Connectors, Tastemakers	<i>Their judgement is the asset, not their name.</i>
SUPPLY	Has, or hears about, the goods	Landlords, Fixtures, Hospitality, Design, Creatives	<i>Their stuff finds a better room.</i>
MODEL	Wants to know why it works	Finance, Tech, Media	<i>Trust built first, marketplace on top.</i>

The two descriptions

Spoken — short. The default. Memorise this one.

“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. A member has to vouch for you to get in — and if you behave badly, they go too.”

SPOKEN — LONG, ONLY IF THEY LEAN IN *“It’s an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Apartments, furniture, whatever you need. A member has to vouch for you to get in, and they stay responsible for you: break the rules and you’re both out. So people are careful about who they bring in. Think about your group chat. Someone posts that they’ve got a spare room going, and you trust it straight away, because you know exactly who you’re dealing with. That’s the feeling I’m building.”*

WRITTEN — THE INVITATION Manhattanite is an invite-only listings site for New Yorkers. Apartments, furniture, things worth passing on. The same stuff you’d find on any classifieds site. **The difference is who’s on it.** A member has to vouch for you before you can join, and they stay responsible for you afterwards. If you break the rules, you’re both removed. So people are careful and considered about who they bring in. Think about your group chat. Someone mentions they’ve got a spare room going and you trust it straight away, because you know exactly who you’re dealing with. That’s what I’m building, at the scale of a city. It’s small on purpose. I’m choosing the first ten members by hand, and I’d like you to be one of them.

NEVER Never volunteer Craigslist, Raya or the word “startup” — let them make the comparison and agree warmly when they do. Never name jobs or services; apartments and furniture are what’s live. Never say “your voucher” in writing. Ten members, not twenty.

The cards

Young professional / mover **PAIN**

ANGLE *“You know what it’s like trying to find anything here. Scams, flakes, people who don’t show. On this, whoever you’re dealing with was let in by someone who’s now answerable for them.”*

ASK What are they hunting for or offloading right now? That becomes their first search or first listing.

WATCH FOR They convert on their own story. Ask “what’s your worst marketplace story?” then land the opener on top of their answer.

Established local **PRIDE**

ANGLE *“The first ten members set the standard for everyone who comes after. I want people whose judgement about other people I’d trust.”*

ASK Lean on question 2. They know exactly who they’d vouch for, and their vouches carry.

WATCH FOR Don’t oversell. Confidence, not flattery. They join because it’s serious, not because you need them.

Newcomer to the city **PAIN**

ANGLE *“This is the network people spend ten years building, and you’d have it on day one — except everyone in it has somebody answering for them.”*

ASK What are they hunting for right now?

WATCH FOR They may feel they have nothing to offer. Tell them newcomers make the market. They’re the buyers and the renters.

Connector — knows everyone **PRIDE**

ANGLE *“You already make introductions for free. Here they count for something, and they cost you something too — which is exactly what makes them worth having.”*

ASK Skip question 1, go straight to question 2. They’ll offer ten names; take three.

WATCH FOR Say the liability part out loud to this type above all. A connector who vouches casually is the single biggest risk to the standard. Hold the ceiling even when they hand you a list.

Neighbourhood fixture — shop / café / staff **SUPPLY**

ANGLE *“You hear who’s moving before their landlord does. Here that’s worth something.”*

ASK Send the person, not the tip. When someone mentions moving out, that’s an invite moment.

WATCH FOR This pitch happens across a counter, not over email. Casual and short.

Apartment supply — landlord / buildings **SUPPLY**

ANGLE *“Every enquiry comes from someone a member let in and stays answerable for. Not anonymous strangers — you can see who brought them in.”*

ASK One vacancy or sublet as a first listing.

WATCH FOR Fair housing. The listing describes the apartment, never the wanted tenant. You approve or decline; you never rewrite. Never say “likeminded” or anything about the type of person — the standard is conduct, not who people are.

Tastemaker — has an audience **PRIDE**

ANGLE *“It’s small on purpose, and the first ten decide what it becomes. I’d rather you shaped it than heard about it later.”*

ASK Membership only. Do NOT ask them to post about it — seed phase is private.

WATCH FOR They can smell being wanted for reach. The pitch is being early, not being a channel.

Creative — artist / musician / designer **SUPPLY**

ANGLE *“Artists already run on word of mouth — sublets, gear, spaces. This is the same thing with a search bar.”*

ASK First listing: the amp, the flat file, the summer sublet.

WATCH FOR Price sensitivity. Lead with “free to join, free to browse” before they have to ask.

Design & interiors **SUPPLY**

ANGLE *“Somewhere the things for sale are actually good, and photographed like it matters. Your pieces deserve a better room.”*

ASK List one piece. Their photography sets the standard for the whole site.

WATCH FOR Business accounts are out of scope. Invite the person, not the studio. Client-offload pieces park until later.

Media / writer **MODEL**

ANGLE *“Tell the long spoken version, then the proof: there’s a French site called Gens de Confiance running on the same single rule. Two million members. Nothing like it here.”*

ASK “I’m not pitching coverage — that comes much later, if ever. I want you in it as a member.”

WATCH FOR Saying “no press yet” makes it more interesting to them, not less. The embargo is part of the pitch.

Finance / business **MODEL**

ANGLE *“It filters the way you already filter everything — through people who’ve put something of their own at risk on the recommendation.”*

ASK Question 2, hard. Their vouches tend to be fast and high quality.

WATCH FOR They’ll ask about the business model. One line: “Pay-per-post later. Membership free forever.” Then move on.

Tech / startup **MODEL**

ANGLE *“Every marketplace bolts trust on at the end — reviews, badges, dispute resolution. I built the trust first and the marketplace on top of it.”*

ASK Both questions work as written.

WATCH FOR “How does this scale?” is coming. The answer: “Slowly, on purpose.” The restraint is the model.

Other / unclassified

ANGLE *“Open, picture, two questions.”*

ASK If the conversation goes well you’ll know their motive by the end — retype them in the tracker.

WATCH FOR If you forget everything: opener, their motive, the two questions. That’s a complete pitch.

Practice drill — 10 minutes

1. Say the spine out loud three times, until beats 1, 3 and 4 are automatic.
2. Shuffle: pick names off the tracker at random. Say the motive out loud, then the angle line.
3. Before each coffee: 60 seconds. Motive, angle line, tailored ask. Nothing else.

If you forget everything mid-conversation: opener, their motive, the two questions. That's a complete pitch.